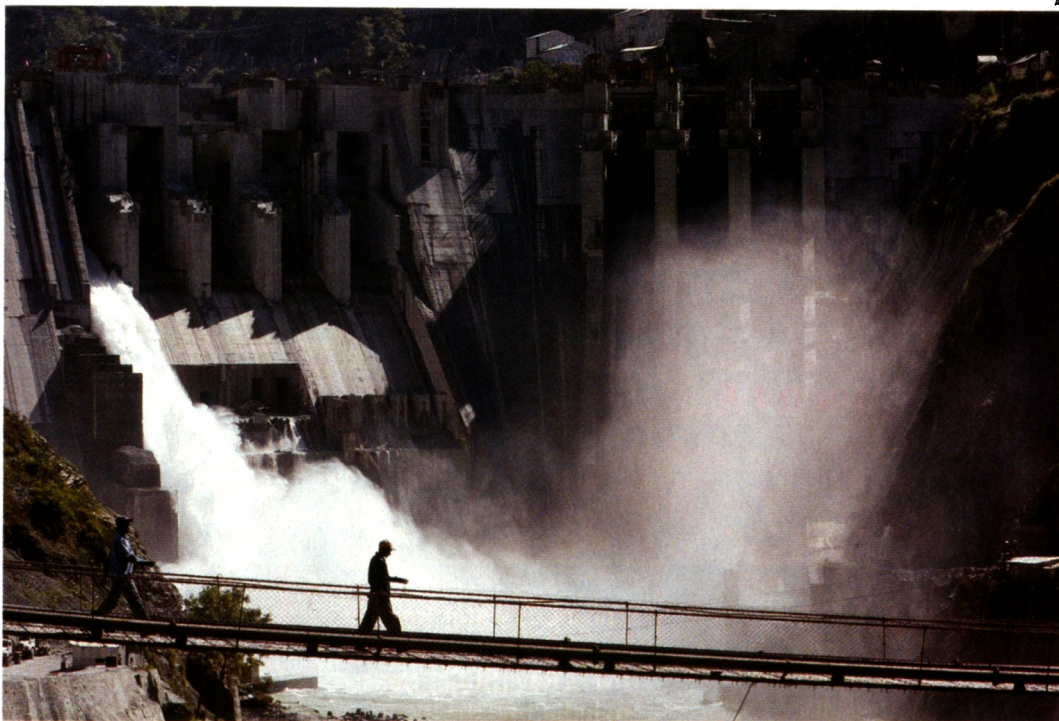


RIVERS OF CONFLICT

Water disputes between India and its land neighbours ratchet up tensions and give rise to fears of war



FACE-OFF



■ International arbitration cleared the way for India to go ahead with the Rs 4,500-cr Baglihar project over the Chenab to generate 450 MW power.



■ Pakistan alleges that India is violating the Indus Water Treaty that governs water sharing between them and wants compensation for its farmers.

**BAGLIHAR DAM
FACES PAKISTANI
OPPOSITION**

By Saurabh Shukla

James Bond films have an overdose of action, but they have one thing that is close to reality—the central plots usually spot global faultlines right. In the latest one, *Quantum of Solace*, the plot involves a rogue organisation trying to trade off lucrative water supply contracts in exchange of support for a coup attempt by a renegade military commander. It's no longer the quest for territory or even oil, but it may be that the squabble for water resources could trigger the conflicts of the future. And closer home, in India's

immediate neighbourhood, water issues are creating problems.

Weighed down by projections that the per capita availability of water in India may go down drastically, and with estimates that India would have a power shortfall of about 70,000 mw at the end of the 12th Five Year Plan, the Government wants to increase the number of hydropower projects. This would mean closer cooperation with neighbours with access to water resources—something giving South Block anxious moments. India is now engaged in resolving numerous water-related disputes with almost all its land neighbours—Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal and China.

In September this year, when Prime Minister Manmohan Singh met Pakistani President Asif Ali Zardari on the sidelines of the United Nations General Assembly, water issues topped the agenda and if the recent sabre-rattling by Islamabad is any indication, the focus may soon shift from the K word to the W word for water. Last month, diplomatic sources say, Pakistan officially raised the issue at the Indus Water Commission meeting, seeking compensation for its farmers and accusing India of diverting the water of the Jhelum. It has alleged that India has reduced the flow of the Chenab to less than 55,000 cusecs, which Pakistan is entitled to under the